Setas de Sevilla

Setas de Sevilla - a humanized audio tour

“A bold gesture that connects archaeology, daily life, and contemporary design.”

— The Setas de Sevilla, fifteen years after opening - now widely recognised as a symbol of modern Seville

20 TRACKS / ~66 MINUTES
SEVILLE, SPAIN / WORLD'S LARGEST WOODEN STRUCTURE



V4 HUMANIZED AUDIO TOUR

About This Tour

WHAT THIS IS

A walking audio tour through one of the most ambitious works of contemporary architecture in southern Europe — the Setas de Sevilla, locally known as Las Setas (The Mushrooms). Built 2005-2011 on the site of the old Mercado de la Encarnación in Seville's medieval centre, designed by German architect Jürgen Mayer H., engineered by Arup, constructed by Sacyr. Six interconnected wooden parasols 28.5 metres tall, 150 metres long, 70 metres wide, made of approximately 3,400 micro-laminated Finnish pine Kerto LVL modules — marketed as the world's largest wooden structure. Four levels: the Antiquarium below (Roman and Almohad ruins discovered during construction in 2003, preserved in place); the food market at ground level; an elevated public plaza; and a 250-metre rooftop walkway with 360-degree views of central Seville at 28 metres up. The structure opened to controversy (€102 million final cost vs. €50 million initial estimate; a trademark dispute over the original Metropol Parasol name) and has since become one of Seville's most visited attractions. Most travelers visit Seville once. This tour is built so that one visit feels like enough — and so the memories last.

HOW TO USE IT

Twenty tracks. About 65-70 minutes of audio across the whole visit. Each track is intentionally short, 3-4 minutes, because the Setas is a rooftop experience first — the view itself deserves your attention, and the audio is there to give you context between sections, not to compete with what you're looking at. Plan two hours total for the whole site if you want to do the Antiquarium plus the walkway in one visit. Plan three hours if you also want to come back for Aurora, the evening light show. The tour follows the natural visitor route: start at street level, descend into the Antiquarium archaeology below, return to ground level, ascend through the market and elevated plaza to the walkway, then back down. Each track opens with a Stop and Look note telling you where to stand. Pause anytime. Your standard ticket includes two visits within 48 hours — so a daytime visit and an evening Aurora return cost the same as a single ticket.

WHAT'S COVERED

The full layered story. History of the site: the Augustinian Convento de la Encarnación (16th century), the Mendizábal disentailment of 1836, Melchor Cano's Mercado de la Encarnación (1842), the market's demolition (1973), and the 37-year hole in the heart of Seville. The 2003 archaeological discovery: Roman houses with mosaic floors, fish-salting tanks, streets, and an Almohad house with a noria waterwheel. The Antiquarium: 4,879 m² archaeological hall plus 550 m² walkway, 400 m of glass walkways, 11 separate areas of remains spanning the 1st century BC to the 13th century. The mosaic houses: Casa de la Columna (5th century AD) with marble pedestals and laurel wreath motifs; Casa de Baco with elaborate Bacchic drinking vessels; the Medusa mosaic on the floor; the kissing birds wall reconstruction (the museum's symbol). The Almohad House of the Waterwheel (12th-13th century). The 2004 international competition: 65 entries, jury including Toyo Ito and Jacques Herzog, Jürgen Mayer's winning Metropol Parasol

design. The architectural inspirations: the vaults of Seville Cathedral and the centenarian ficus trees in Plaza Cristo de Burgos. The engineering: Arup, 3,400 Kerto Q LVL modules from Metsä Wood (Aichach, Germany), only six vertical supports (two concrete cores housing lifts, four timber-composite supports), polyurethane resin connections, custom weather coating. The four levels and how they work. The 250-metre rooftop walkway and the views: Giralda, Triana, Macarena, Guadalquivir, Alameda de Hércules. The controversy (dedicated track): €102 million final cost, the Mayer trademark on Metropol Parasol that led to the official adoption of Setas de Sevilla in 2013, the public reception over 15 years. Feeling Sevilla (multisensory film) and Aurora (AI-driven LED light show that never repeats). Practical visitor information, 2026 ticket structure, opening hours, the 48-hour double-entry ticket, accessibility, and what to see next in Seville.

ON SOURCES

Every claim in this tour was verified against primary sources before it was written: the official Setas de Sevilla site at setasdesevilla.com (T1a), official Andalusian regional tourism at andalucia.org and the Junta de Andalucía's heritage documentation (T1b), Arup's published engineering documentation, Arquitectura Viva, ArchDaily, Archello (T2), and a range of independent T3 specialists (Lonely Planet, Andalucia.com, Seville Concierge, GetYourGuide, Civitatis, Andalucía Exclusiva). Several common tourist claims were corrected after verification — including the precise dimensions (the structure's height varies in citations between 26m, 27m, and 28.5m at different reference points — the maximum is 28.5m), the date of the archaeological discovery (2003, when excavation for the new car park began, not 2004 when the architectural competition was announced), and the careful distinction between the structure's two names (Metropol Parasol — Jürgen Mayer's original trademarked name, used in architectural press and awards; Setas de Sevilla — the official municipal name since 2013, after the city declined to pay royalties on the architect's trademark).

VOICE

Reverent but grounded. Storytelling-forward. Companion, not commander. The Setas de Sevilla is unusual in the catalog of European architectural visits — it is a contemporary work built on top of an ancient one, and the tour treats both layers seriously. Each track is short by design because the rooftop walkway is one of the great urban panoramas of southern Europe and visitors should be looking, not listening. The tour also acknowledges the controversy that surrounded the building's construction and the trademark dispute that produced its current official name. Most audio guides skip the awkward parts. This one does not — because most people only visit Seville once, and they deserve to take home not just the wonder but the truth.

Tracks

01	Welcome	★	~2.7 min
02	A Convent, a Market, a Car Park, a Hole		~2.5 min
03	The 2003 Discovery		~2.7 min
04	The Antiquarium	★★	~2.5 min
05	The Mosaic Houses		~2.6 min
06	Medusa, the Kissing Birds, and the Laurel Wreath		~2.6 min
07	The Almohad House of the Waterwheel		~2.7 min
08	The 2004 Competition		~2.3 min
09	Inspiration		~2.4 min
10	The Engineering	★★	~2.6 min
11	The Mercado de la Encarnación, Reborn		~2.5 min
12	The Elevated Plaza		~2.2 min
13	The Walkway	★★	~2.7 min
14	The View	★★	~2.5 min
15	The Controversy		~2.9 min
16	Feeling Sevilla		~2.7 min
17	Aurora	★★	~3.0 min
18	What Seville Decided About Itself		~2.8 min
19	Around the Square		~2.8 min
20	What's Next		~3.0 min

TRACK 01 / 20

Welcome

★ ANCHOR

> **STOP & LOOK**
> *Stand in Plaza de la Encarnación, at the base of the wooden structure. Look up. The canopy stretches 150 metres in one direction and 70 in the other, supported on only six concrete columns. The ground floor is open - you can walk under it without a ticket. Find a spot in the shade and pause before you do anything else.*

Welcome. Take a breath.

The thing above you was not supposed to look like this.

In two thousand four, the city of Seville held an architectural competition. The brief was simple - design something to fill a hole in the middle of the old quarter. The hole had been a market for seventy years. Then a car park for thirty. Then a building site for seven. Seville needed someone to close it.

Sixty-five architects from around the world submitted proposals. A jury that included the Japanese architect Toyo Ito and the Swiss architect Jacques Herzog picked the most daring, the most expensive, the most controversial of all sixty-five. The winning design was by a German architect from Berlin named Jürgen Mayer. It called for six gigantic wooden parasols, twenty-eight metres tall, made of three thousand four hundred individual timber modules glued together, hovering over the medieval centre of one of the oldest cities in Spain.

Seven years of construction, multiple delays, a hundred and two million euros, and one Roman archaeological site discovered in the middle of it all later, the parasols opened to the public in twenty eleven.

Locals immediately renamed them Las Setas. The Mushrooms.

The name stuck so completely that in twenty thirteen, when the city discovered that Mayer himself had trademarked the original name Metropol Parasol and would charge for its use, the council officially adopted the people's name. Today the structure is the Setas de Sevilla. The Mushrooms of Seville. There is no other building in Europe with a more affectionately ridiculous official name.

Here's how we'll walk it. Twenty tracks. About seventy minutes of audio across the whole experience - but here's the important thing. You do not need to listen to me while you're up on the walkway looking at Seville. The view deserves your eyes. The audio is there to give you context before you go up, and to pull pieces together as you move between the levels. Most of what's worth seeing here is best experienced in silence.

So - here is the plan. We'll start at ground level, then descend into the Antiquarium to meet the Roman city beneath your feet. We'll come back up, look at the engineering of the structure, walk up to the elevated plaza, and only then climb to the rooftop walkway. Aurora, the light show, is best caught at night - we'll talk about how to time that.

Let's go down first. The Roman city is underneath you.

TRACK 02 / 20

A Convent, a Market, a Car Park, a Hole

CONTEXT

> **STOP & LOOK**
> *Still at street level in Plaza de la Encarnación. Look around the square. The buildings on the perimeter are eighteenth and nineteenth century - tile-fronted, four or five storeys, balconied. The Setas occupy where the centre of the square used to be open. This was empty ground for nearly forty years.*

The square has been a hole for most of living memory.

Before that, it was a market. And before that, a convent. And the layers go back further than that - we'll get to that in a moment.

In the sixteenth century the Augustinian order built a convent here called the Convento de la Encarnación - the Convent of the Incarnation. That's where the plaza gets its name. The convent stood for almost three hundred years. It was demolished in the nineteenth century during one of the great waves of Spanish anticlerical reform, the Mendizábal disentailment of eighteen thirty-six, when the Spanish state confiscated monastic properties across the country.

What replaced it was a market. In eighteen forty-two, the architect Melchor Cano - a major figure in nineteenth-century Sevillian architecture - designed the Mercado de la Encarnación. The market opened with more than four hundred stalls selling fresh produce, meat, fish, and bread. It became the central food market of the entire city. Sevillanos lived around it, shopped at it, met there, gossiped there. For one hundred and thirty years, the rhythm of life in this neighbourhood was the rhythm of the market.

In nineteen seventy-three, the market was demolished.

The reasons were a slow accumulation. The stalls for vegetables and fish had developed serious structural problems. The Tamarguillo flood of nineteen sixty-one had damaged the foundations. And the first supermarkets had begun to appear in Seville - the supermarket model that was about to transform European food shopping was undermining the central market everywhere it touched.

So the market came down. The traders were moved to temporary facilities nearby - facilities that were supposed to last three years. They lasted thirty-seven. The site of the original market became a car park. An underground car park, paving the surface as a flat plaza on top.

The car park was supposed to be temporary too. It lasted from nineteen seventy-three to two thousand three. Thirty years of a flat asphalt plaza in the middle of one of the most beautiful old cities in Europe.

In two thousand three the city finally committed to redeveloping it. The plan was to demolish the car park, redesign the square, build something new. The diggers moved in.

That is when they hit a wall of Roman masonry. We'll talk about that in the next track.

TRACK 03 / 20

The 2003 Discovery

CONTEXT

> **STOP & LOOK**
> *Still at ground level. Walk over to the entrance of the Antiquarium - it's on level minus one, signposted, accessed from inside the structure on the side facing the eighteenth-century buildings. You can see ruins through plate-glass windows before you even buy a ticket. Don't go in yet. Stand at the glass.*

This is where the project went wrong, and then went right.

The diggers had started clearing the old car park in two thousand three. The plan was straightforward: remove the existing structure, deepen the foundations, build a new underground car park, lay a new market on top, and rebuild the square. Nobody on the construction team expected to find anything historical.

Then someone hit masonry.

The masonry was Roman. A clean line of dressed stone, an early imperial pattern, with a section of mosaic floor still in place beside it. The construction crew called in the archaeologists. The archaeologists started digging. What had looked like a quick foundation job turned into one of the most significant urban archaeological excavations in modern Spanish history.

By the time the digging was done they had uncovered eleven separate areas of remains. Seven Roman houses with mosaic floors, columns, and wells. Streets between the houses. Industrial fish-salting tanks - the Romans of southern Spain made an enormous business out of garum, the fermented fish sauce that was their version of soy sauce. And on top of the Roman city, the foundations of an Almohad house from the twelfth or thirteenth century, complete with the housing for a noria, a vertical waterwheel.

The earliest finds dated to the first century before Christ. The latest dated to the thirteenth century. Roman, Visigothic, early Islamic, and Almohad - over a thousand years of continuous urban occupation, sitting four to five metres below the surface of a twentieth-century car park.

This is not unusual for Seville. The whole city sits on top of itself. Seville is two thousand four hundred years old as a settlement. Before the Romans called it Hispalis, the Phoenicians had a trading post here. Before the Phoenicians, the Tartessians. The historic centre is a sandwich of urban layers, each one built on the rubble and the foundations of the last.

But the size of what they had found here was significant. And the city had a choice to make. Demolish the ruins and build the car park as planned. Or rebuild the entire project around the archaeology, preserving everything in place.

They chose the second. The architectural competition that produced the Setas had not even been announced yet. The competition brief was rewritten to include the Antiquarium. Whatever the winning architect designed had to float above the ruins on the smallest possible number of supports. That constraint is what produced the six-column structure you're standing under right now.

Let's go down to meet them. The Antiquarium is the next track.

TRACK 04 / 20

The Antiquarium

★★ HERO

> **STOP & LOOK**
> *Buy your Antiquarium ticket - it's separate from the Setas walkway ticket, around two and a half euros, free with a Real Alcázar ticket. Take the stairs or lift down to level minus one. You'll come out into a low, dim, atmospheric space, with glass walkways running over the ruins. Stand at the first walkway and just look down for a minute.*

You are now four to five metres below the modern street.

Above you - in the equivalent height of a small two-storey building - is the elevated plaza, the market, the wooden canopy, the walkway, and the open sky. Below you is the Seville of the Romans.

The space is enormous. Four thousand eight hundred and seventy-nine square metres of archaeological hall, plus another five hundred and fifty of approach walkway. Almost five thousand square metres of preserved ancient city, in place, with the walls and floors arranged exactly as they were found. The architect of this underground space was Felipe Palomino. He designed the surrounding membrane - a vast hanging curtain of glass that wraps around the entire archaeological hall, lit from above and behind, so that the ruins seem to glow softly without obvious light sources. The effect is deliberately atmospheric. Many visitors describe it as feeling like a temple, or like the bottom of a slow river.

You can walk above the ruins on raised glass walkways. The total length of walkways inside the Antiquarium is about four hundred metres. From the walkways you look down onto Roman mosaic floors, Roman wells, Roman streets, the foundations of Roman houses, the fish-salting tanks, and the later Almohad house on top.

The temporal span here is unusual. Most ancient sites in Europe represent one civilisation. Pompeii is Roman. Stonehenge is prehistoric. The Forum in Rome is Roman. But the Antiquarium spans more than thirteen centuries on a single site. The earliest layers are first-century before Christ - Republican Roman, before the empire even existed. The Roman houses you can see are mostly second to fifth century AD. Then there's a gap - Visigothic remains exist but are less visible to a casual visitor. Then the Almohad house from the twelfth and thirteenth centuries, when Seville was a major city of the Western Islamic world, capital of an empire that stretched from southern Spain across North Africa to Senegal.

All of it preserved in place, all of it visible at once, all of it sitting underneath six wooden mushrooms that locals named at a coffee in twenty eleven.

The next track is about the specific houses. Move into the main archaeological hall and walk to the first large rectangular space on your right. That's the Casa de la Columna.

TRACK 05 / 20

The Mosaic Houses

OBJECT

> **STOP & LOOK**
> *Walk into the main hall of the Antiquarium. Find the Casa de la Columna - it's the largest single Roman house on display, with a clear pillared patio at the centre and a mosaic floor running around it. Stand at the glass railing.*

This is the Casa de la Columna. The House of the Column.

It dates from the fifth century after Christ. By Roman standards that's late - the western Roman empire was collapsing in this period - but the house was substantial. Look at the pillared patio at its centre. The marble pedestals are still in place where the columns once stood. The house was built around this courtyard in the typical Roman pattern - rooms opening off a central open-air space, with the family living around the courtyard and using it for light, air, and drainage.

The mosaic floor around the patio is the centrepiece. You can see laurel wreath motifs - the curved garland of leaves that Roman emperors wore as crowns and that athletes wore at the Olympic games. You can also see diadem motifs - the simple circular crown of bands wrapped around the head, similar to the laurel in meaning. Both designs were popular in the later Roman empire, when Roman patrons were increasingly drawing on Greek visual vocabulary to signal cultural sophistication.

Move on through the hall and you'll find the Casa de Baco. The House of Bacchus, the Roman god of wine.

This one is smaller but more visually striking. The mosaic floor has a central image of Bacchus, surrounded by an ornamental border. The corners of the mosaic show elaborate drinking vessels - kraters and kantharos cups - the kind of fine pottery used at Roman dinner parties for serving wine. The house belonged to someone who wanted dinner guests to know that wine was being taken seriously. The Romans of southern Spain produced enormous quantities of wine for the empire - Hispania Baetica, the Roman province that contained Hispalis, was one of the major wine exporters of the western Mediterranean. The Casa de Baco is, in a quiet way, a portrait of that economy.

Both houses are from the late Roman period. Both were destroyed and abandoned - not in a single catastrophic event, but through the slow urban contraction of the fifth and sixth centuries, as the western empire fragmented and the population of Hispalis declined. The Visigothic and early Islamic periods reused some of the foundations but built less densely. By the time the Almohad period arrived in the twelfth century, parts of the Roman city had been buried for half a millennium.

Walk on. The smaller mosaics are in the next track.

TRACK 06 / 20

Medusa, the Kissing Birds, and the Laurel Wreath

OBJECT

> **STOP & LOOK**
> *Continue through the Antiquarium. Find the wall-mounted reconstructed mosaic of two facing birds with their beaks touching - that's the kissing birds, the symbol of the museum. Nearby on the floor you'll find a circular Medusa mosaic with the snake-haired goddess at the centre. Stand near them.*

The kissing birds are the symbol of the Antiquarium.

Originally a floor mosaic, the museum has reconstructed them on a wall so visitors can see them at eye level. Two birds face each other, beaks touching. The image is simpler than the larger figural mosaics, almost abstract - flat colours, geometric border, a clear visual gesture. The birds are doves, or possibly partridges - the species is not certain. The mosaic dates from the third or fourth century AD.

What it meant in the original house, nobody knows for sure. It could be a domestic decorative motif. It could refer to a particular Roman myth about devoted bird couples. It could just be beautiful - the Romans, like every other ancient civilisation, sometimes made beautiful things for no greater reason than beauty.

The Medusa mosaic is more famous mythologically but less rare as an image.

Medusa was one of the Gorgons - a monster with snakes for hair and a gaze that turned people to stone. In Greek and Roman myth she was killed by the hero Perseus, who used her severed head as a weapon, since the petrifying gaze still worked after death. The image of the Medusa head, the gorgoneion, was used throughout the Roman empire as an apotropaic motif - a symbol meant to ward off evil. You see Medusa heads on Roman shields, on temple doorways, on jewellery, and on house floors. Walking over a Medusa mosaic at the entrance to a Roman house was understood to bring protection from misfortune.

This particular Medusa is laid out on the floor. The face is at the centre, the snakes radiate outward in a circular border, and a square frame contains the whole composition. The colours are the standard palette of Roman floor mosaic - black, white, red ochre, terracotta, occasionally yellow.

The laurel wreath motif you saw in the Casa de la Columna also appears in smaller mosaics throughout the Antiquarium. The laurel was sacred to Apollo and was used both for athletic victory and for imperial coronation. By the late Roman period it had become a generic decorative motif - the equivalent of decorative gilt edging in nineteenth-century European interiors. You see it everywhere in late Roman house decoration.

Walk to the far end of the archaeological hall. The Almohad house is the next layer up, chronologically. We'll meet it in the next track.

TRACK 07 / 20

The Almohad House of the Waterwheel

OBJECT

> **STOP & LOOK**
> *Find the section of the Antiquarium where the masonry style changes. You'll see brick rather than dressed stone, smaller and lower walls, and a deep square or circular shaft - the housing for the noria, the vertical waterwheel. Stand near it.*

This is the Casa de la Noria. The House of the Waterwheel.

It is Almohad, twelfth to thirteenth century - about seven hundred years younger than the Roman houses next to it.

The Almohads were a Berber dynasty from North Africa who conquered the western Islamic world in the twelfth century. At their peak they controlled most of Morocco, all of Andalusia, and parts of what is now Algeria and Tunisia. Their capital alternated between Marrakech and Seville. Their architectural legacy in Seville is enormous - the Giralda, the cathedral's bell tower, was originally the minaret of the Almohad great mosque, built in the eleven hundred and eighties. The Torre del Oro on the river is Almohad. Parts of the Real Alcázar palace are built on Almohad foundations.

This domestic house is a quieter piece of the same period. It's built in brick rather than the dressed stone the Romans used. The walls are lower and the rooms smaller. The defining feature is the housing for the noria - a vertical waterwheel, powered by an animal or by flowing water, used to raise water from a well or cistern up to the level of a domestic garden or fountain.

Norias were essential to Islamic urban life in Andalusia. The medieval Islamic cities of the Iberian peninsula were famous across the Mediterranean for the sophistication of their water systems - aqueducts, cisterns, canals, fountains in private courtyards, public baths. The noria was one of the technologies that made this possible. Walk through any garden of the Real Alcázar and the water that runs through the channels was once raised by something like the wheel that used to turn here.

The house itself was a relatively modest urban residence. Not a palace - just a comfortable home for a merchant or middle-ranking official in twelfth or thirteenth century Seville. The same kind of person who, if they had lived a thousand years earlier on the same plot, would have owned the Casa de Baco above.

The Almohad presence in Seville ended in twelve forty-eight, when the Castilian king Fernando III conquered the city. Most Almohad public architecture survived the conquest - the Christians reused the mosque as a cathedral, the minaret as a bell tower. But Almohad domestic architecture was largely demolished and rebuilt over the following centuries. This house survived

because it was buried.

Walk back up to street level now. We're coming above ground to look at how the structure above you was made.

TRACK 08 / 20

The 2004 Competition

CONTEXT

> **STOP & LOOK**
> *Back at street level, in Plaza de la Encarnación. Step back from the structure so you can see all six parasols at once. Notice where the supports come down to the ground - there are only six of them, two of which are the larger concrete cores housing the elevators.*

The competition that produced this structure took place in two thousand four.

The city of Seville's redevelopment agency, called EMVISESA, ran an international architectural competition for the redesign of Plaza de la Encarnación. The brief was complicated. Whatever the winner designed had to: rebuild the food market that had stood on the site until nineteen seventy-three; create a new public plaza; preserve the Roman and Almohad archaeology that had just been discovered; and create some kind of contemporary architectural signature that would put this neglected corner of Seville back on the cultural map.

Sixty-five proposals arrived from architects around the world.

The international jury was led by Spanish architects but included two of the most prominent international names in the profession - Toyo Ito, the Japanese architect who later won the Pritzker Prize in twenty thirteen, and Jacques Herzog, of the Swiss firm Herzog and de Meuron, which had designed Tate Modern in London and the Bird's Nest stadium in Beijing.

The winner was a German architect named Jürgen Mayer H. He was forty years old, based in Berlin, and had not yet built any project at this scale. His proposal was titled Metropol Parasol. It called for six enormous wooden parasols, twenty-eight metres tall, arranged in a loose grid above the square, with a market underneath, an elevated plaza at the level of the parasol bases, a rooftop walkway running through the canopies, and the Antiquarium preserved at basement level.

The jury chose it because it was the most ambitious. The most expensive too - the initial budget was fifty million euros. The most engineering-intensive. The most uncompromising in its commitment to the archaeology underneath. Of the sixty-five entries, it was the one that took the constraint of having to float above the Roman city most seriously and turned it into the central idea of the design.

It was also the riskiest. Nobody had ever built a wooden structure this size before. The materials, the engineering, the construction process, the maintenance, the safety - all of it had to be invented as the project went along. The jury knew this. They chose it anyway.

The engineering challenge is the next track.

TRACK 09 / 20

Inspiration

OBJECT

> **STOP & LOOK**
> *Step back further if you can - across the square to one of the cafés on the perimeter. Look at the canopy as a whole, with its undulating roof line and the way the six parasols merge at the top into a single connected mass. Try to forget that it's wood for a moment and just look at the shape.*

Jürgen Mayer was open about where the design came from.

Two inspirations, both Sevillian, both anchored in places you can walk to in twenty minutes from here.

The first was the Cathedral of Seville. Specifically, the vaulted ceilings of the cathedral nave. The cathedral is a fifteen-century late Gothic structure - the largest Gothic cathedral in the world by area - built between fourteen thirty-four and fifteen seventeen, on the foundations of the Almohad mosque. The vaults rise to forty-two metres at the highest point. They are made of stone ribs that branch outward from columnar piers, splay across the ceiling, and meet other branches halfway, forming a continuous interlocking pattern of structural curves.

Stand under the cathedral vaults and look up, and you'll recognise what Mayer was doing here. The Setas are an inverted cathedral. The same branching structural pattern, the same sense of a canopy held up by columns, the same play between mass and lightness - but built outdoors in wood instead of indoors in stone, and inverted so that the branches spread above your head into open sky instead of containing you inside a closed religious space.

The second inspiration was a tree. Or rather, a grove of trees. Three minutes' walk from here, in a small square called Plaza Cristo de Burgos, there are several enormous mature ficus trees - common Spanish name ficus de Bengala, the same species you find in tropical street plantings across the world. The ficus in Plaza Cristo de Burgos are over a hundred years old, with trunks two metres thick and canopies that span the entire square.

Walk under them and look up. You'll see exactly the geometry of the Setas. The branches spread laterally, interlocking with their neighbours, casting a dense dappled shade over the ground. The canopy is generous, sheltering, and feels organic in the way that only natural growth can. The Setas are an architectural ficus tree. Six of them. Made of three thousand four hundred pieces of Finnish pine.

The pairing is significant. A cathedral and a tree. The two great forms of canopy that medieval Spain knew - the human one and the natural one. Mayer combined them into a single architectural gesture.

The engineering that made it possible is the next track.

TRACK 10 / 20

The Engineering

★★ HERO

STOP & LOOK
Stand at the base of one of the concrete supports. There are two main concrete cores that house the elevators - they're the larger, opaquer columns. The other supports are slimmer. Touch the surface of one of them - you can feel the texture of the timber.

Three thousand four hundred timber modules. Six vertical supports. Twenty-eight metres tall. One hundred and fifty metres long. The largest wooden structure in the world.

The engineering was done by Arup, the London-based engineering firm responsible for some of the most ambitious structural projects of the late twentieth and early twenty-first centuries - the Sydney Opera House roof, the Centre Pompidou in Paris, the Bird's Nest stadium in Beijing. Arup's role here was to take Jürgen Mayer's architectural vision and figure out how to actually build it.

The first decision was the material. Mayer wanted wood - the cathedral-vault inspiration would only work if the canopy felt warm and organic, which steel could not have provided. Arup's engineers looked at the available high-performance timber products and settled on Kerto LVL - laminated veneer lumber. Specifically Kerto Q, a grade engineered for high structural loads. Each Kerto module is made of thin layers of Finnish pine veneer, glued together under pressure with alternating grain directions, producing a wood-composite material that is far stronger than solid timber of equivalent dimensions.

The Kerto came from a Finnish company called Metsä Wood. The modules were manufactured at Metsä's factory in Aichach, Germany. Each one was custom-shaped - three thousand four hundred individual pieces, no two exactly the same, each precisely cut to fit a specific position in the canopy.

The modules were glued together with a custom polyurethane resin designed to withstand the high summer temperatures of southern Spain. The exterior was coated with a two-component polyurethane weather sealant. Finished assembly began on site in two thousand nine, after two years of prefabrication in Germany.

The six-support constraint - imposed by the archaeology below - was the structural problem. Six supports for a hundred-and-fifty by seventy metre canopy is extreme. The canopy effectively cantilevers outward from each support for thirty to forty metres in multiple directions. Arup solved it by making two of the central supports into concrete-and-steel cores that carry most of the vertical load and house the lifts, while the other four are pure timber-and-steel composites that mainly resist the lateral and rotational forces.

The canopy is reinforced by diagonal stiffeners below the rooftop walkways. You won't see these from below - they're concealed - but they are what allow the long horizontal spans to stay rigid against wind load.

You're now ready to go up. Take the lift to level two.

TRACK 11 / 20

The Mercado de la Encarnación, Reborn

OBJECT

> **STOP & LOOK**
> *Take the escalator or stairs up to level 1 - the ground level of the market that sits underneath the wooden parasols. You're now inside the food market. Look around: stalls of fresh produce, fish, meat, baked goods, and small cafés. Pause near any of them.*

The market reopened on the nineteenth of December two thousand ten.

That date is meaningful. It came thirty-seven years after the original Mercado de la Encarnación was demolished in nineteen seventy-three - thirty-seven years in which the descendants of the original traders had been working out of temporary stalls a few hundred metres away.

When the Setas project was being designed, the city committed that the new market would honour the heritage of the old one. Where possible, the original families who had run the market in nineteen seventy-three were given priority on stalls. Not all of them came back - some had retired, some had moved on, some had built up other businesses. But the core trades remained: fresh vegetables, fruit, fish, meat, eggs, cheese, bread, olives, jamón ibérico, and the specialised products of Andalusian gastronomy.

The market is a working food market, not a tourist market. Sevillanos shop here. The opening hours follow the rhythm of Spanish working life - the market opens early in the morning, closes mid-afternoon for siesta, and reopens for the early evening if there's demand. The fishmongers at the back are some of the best in the old quarter. Several of the produce stalls supply restaurants in the surrounding streets.

A few of the stalls have been converted into small bars and tapas counters where you can eat what's being sold. This is one of the great Spanish urban traditions - the market that doubles as an informal restaurant. You can buy a glass of wine and a plate of jamón at one stall, then walk over to another and order grilled prawns from the fishmonger's bar, then finish with cheese and an espresso. The whole circuit costs about fifteen euros and is one of the better lunches available in the centre of Seville.

The architectural integration of the market into the larger Setas structure is unobtrusive. You can forget, while you're shopping, that you're standing underneath the largest wooden structure in the world. That's deliberate. The market is supposed to feel like a market, not like a piece of architecture. The wooden canopy above does its work overhead, providing shade and atmospheric framing, while the stalls below get on with the business of selling tomatoes.

Take the escalator up to the elevated plaza. The next track is up there.

TRACK 12 / 20

The Elevated Plaza

OBJECT

> **STOP & LOOK**
> *You're now on level 2, the elevated plaza. It's a flat open platform five metres above ground level, three thousand square metres in area, shaded by the canopy above. There are usually some events being set up or stalls running. Find a clear corner and look outward over the edge.*

This is the level that people often miss.

The walkway above is the famous part of the Setas. The market and Antiquarium below are the dense parts. The elevated plaza here in the middle is the quietest. It's an open public space five metres above the original street level, three thousand square metres in area, shaded by the canopy.

It exists as a separate level for two reasons. First, the structural one - the elevated platform is what visually anchors the parasols and gives them a base. Second, the social one - the city wanted a flexible public events space that could be used independently of the market below and the walkway above.

In practice, the plaza hosts concerts, markets, dance performances, small festivals, public film screenings, and occasional political gatherings. The acoustic properties of the canopy overhead - all that wood, hanging in open air - create an unexpectedly intimate sound environment for a space of this size. Three thousand people can be in this plaza at once, but a single voice on a stage at one end carries to the other.

The plaza is also where you get the best view of the underside of the canopy.

Look up.

From down at street level, the Setas look mushroom-like and organic, but the lattice structure is largely hidden. From up here on the elevated plaza, you can see the structural grid clearly - the rectangular pattern of Kerto modules, the diagonal stiffeners running below the rooftop walkways, the way the canopy thickens at the supports and thins out at the cantilevered edges.

It's an engineer's view of the building. The architecture as architecture. If you came up here in the evening for the Aurora light show, you'd be standing under the projection screen.

This is also where you take the lift up to the rooftop walkway. The lifts are in the two central concrete cores - the larger supports you noticed at ground level. From here it's another twenty-three metres up to the top.

Take the lift now. The walkway is the next track.

TRACK 13 / 20

The Walkway

★★ HERO

STOP & LOOK
You're now at the top of the structure, twenty-eight metres above the plaza. The walkway is a curving timber path that winds across all six parasols. It rises and falls gently as you walk along it. Step out onto the timber. Take a moment to let the height register. Then start walking.

You're now standing higher than almost any other publicly accessible point in central Seville.

The Cathedral's Giralda tower is taller - one hundred and four metres including the bronze weathervane on top - but the Giralda is a single point of view, reached after climbing a ramp inside a stone tower. The Setas walkway is two hundred and fifty metres of horizontal path at this altitude, weaving across all six parasols, with the city opening out around you in every direction.

The path is timber - the same Kerto LVL as the rest of the canopy, treated for foot traffic. It rises and falls in gentle curves. The lowest point of the walkway is about twenty-three metres above the elevated plaza. The highest point, on the central parasols, is about twenty-eight metres. You don't notice the gradient much while you're walking, but the views change as you rise and fall.

The walkway is fully accessible by elevator and ramp for most of its length - about ninety percent. The final viewing platform at the top of one of the central parasols requires a short flight of stairs. If you have mobility limitations, you can still see most of the views from the ramped sections; you'll miss only the very highest deck.

Look down at the timber slats under your feet. There are gaps between them - intentional, to allow rainwater to drain through. Some sections of walkway have glass panels set into the floor, so you can look straight down into the elevated plaza twenty-three metres below. If you have a fear of heights, those panels are the ones to be cautious about.

The handrails are timber too. Run your hand along them as you walk. The grain of the Finnish pine is visible at close range. Some sections have weathered more than others depending on sun exposure - the south-facing rails are silvered, the north-facing ones are still pale yellow.

A small practical note before you start exploring. The walkway is open from nine thirty in the morning to eleven thirty at night, with last entry at eleven. Your ticket allows two visits within forty-eight hours. The most common pattern - and the one I recommend - is to come up once in late afternoon for the daytime view, leave, have dinner in the surrounding streets, and come back after dark for the light show. You don't pay twice.

For now, just walk. The view itself is the next track.

TRACK 14 / 20

The View

★★ HERO

STOP & LOOK
Find the highest viewing point on the walkway - the small upper deck on one of the central parasols. From here you can see all of central Seville. Take your time orienting yourself. The Giralda will be the obvious tall stone tower with a bronze top to the south.

Let me orient you.

The river is to the west. The Guadalquivir runs north to south through Seville, and from this walkway you can see the strip of green along its banks even though the water itself is hidden behind buildings. Beyond the river, slightly elevated, is the neighbourhood of Triana. Triana is one of the oldest neighbourhoods in Seville, traditionally home to potters, sailors, bullfighters, and flamenco singers. The white-and-yellow facades of Triana's old buildings catch the late afternoon light and glow before sunset.

The Cathedral is to the south. The Giralda bell tower is unmistakable - a tall stone tower with a small bronze sculpture on top called the Giraldillo, representing the triumph of Faith. The cathedral itself is the largest Gothic cathedral in the world by area. The Giralda was the minaret of the Almohad great mosque, built in the eleven hundred and eighties, the same century as the Almohad waterwheel house you saw underground. From this distance you can see how the tower dominates the southern half of the old city.

To the north is the Macarena. The Basílica de la Macarena, home of the famous Virgin of the Macarena - the most venerated Madonna statue in the Holy Week processions of Seville - is visible if you know where to look. It's a smaller white-and-yellow basilica with a clear belfry. The Macarena neighbourhood is the working-class heart of old Seville, less touristy than the cathedral area, more authentic in feel.

To the east, the city continues into the modern neighbourhoods. The Alameda de Hércules, a long tree-lined square that has been a centre of Sevillian nightlife since the sixteenth century, is just a few hundred metres in that direction. Beyond it, the old city walls and then the Macarena gate.

In the foreground - directly below the walkway - you can see the rooftops of the eighteenth and nineteenth century buildings around Plaza de la Encarnación. The tile patterns, the small private terraces, the laundry lines, the satellite dishes, the air conditioning units. The everyday life of the city visible from above.

Late afternoon and sunset are the best times for this view. The light softens, the long shadows pick out the relief of the buildings, and the Giralda's bronze top catches the sun. Walk the full

loop of the walkway at least once. The view changes as you move.

TRACK 15 / 20

The Controversy

CONTEXT

> **STOP & LOOK**
> *Find a quieter section of the walkway and pause. This is a listening track - the next four minutes are about the difficult history of how the Setas got built. Don't rush.*

The Setas were controversial from the start. Some of that controversy was earned. Some of it was the inevitable cost of doing something new in an old city.

The first controversy was money. The initial competition brief in two thousand four specified a budget of approximately fifty million euros. By the time construction was complete in twenty eleven, the final cost had risen to one hundred and two million euros - more than double the original estimate. The cost overruns came from a combination of factors. The Roman archaeology discovery in two thousand three forced a major redesign and additional preservation work. The engineering challenge of the wooden canopy required custom solutions that nobody had built before. There were construction delays that added years to the timeline. And the city's contracting process, like many large public projects, was not always efficient.

For Sevillanos, the cost was a political issue. A hundred and two million euros is a significant sum for any European city. The construction overlapped with the start of the global financial crisis in two thousand eight, and Spain was hit harder than most countries. Public spending on a single architectural project, however ambitious, attracted criticism while the country was cutting services elsewhere.

The second controversy was the name.

The project was called Metropol Parasol throughout the design and construction phase. That was Jürgen Mayer's chosen name, and it was used in all the architectural press, all the awards, and all the official communications. When the structure opened in twenty eleven, Sevillanos almost immediately renamed it Las Setas - The Mushrooms - because of the obvious shape.

In twenty thirteen, the city discovered that Jürgen Mayer had personally trademarked the name Metropol Parasol and would charge for its commercial use. Tourist guides, postcards, T-shirts, merchandise - all of it would have to pay royalties to the architect. The city was not amused. They officially adopted the people's name. Setas de Sevilla became the structure's legal designation. The architect's name was, in effect, retired by his own client.

The third controversy was aesthetic. Some Sevillanos hated the structure from day one. A wooden modernist canopy in the middle of a sixteenth and seventeenth century neighbourhood looked like architectural vandalism to traditionalists. The opposition has softened over time but never disappeared. You'll find Sevillanos who, fifteen years after opening, still won't walk through

Plaza de la Encarnación if they can help it.

But the Setas have also become the most visited single structure in the city after the cathedral. A million people a year come up the walkway. The Antiquarium gets a hundred thousand more.

The controversy is part of the story. The next track is about how the city worked out what it thought.

TRACK 16 / 20

Feeling Sevilla

OBJECT

> **STOP & LOOK**
> *If you've taken the lift down to the screening room - it's on the lower levels of the structure - find a seat for the next show. The Feeling Sevilla film runs every fifteen minutes throughout the day. If you've decided to skip it, find a comfortable spot anywhere on the elevated plaza for this track.*

The Feeling Sevilla film is fifteen minutes long. It plays in a small dedicated theatre inside the Setas structure on a fixed loop, every fifteen minutes from ten in the morning to ten at night. Your standard entry ticket includes it.

The film is not a documentary. It's a multisensory immersive experience designed to give visitors who have only a few hours in Seville a compressed emotional sense of what the city feels like. You sit in a small theatre with surround projection on multiple walls. As the film plays, the theatre releases scents - orange blossom, jasmine, leather, fried oil, jamón. The seats produce gentle motion. Air movers create a breeze when the film moves to outdoor scenes.

The content cycles through the iconic Sevillian images. Flamenco dancers at the Tablao. The Feria de Abril in spring with women in flamenco dresses on horseback. The Holy Week processions of Semana Santa. The bullring. The orange groves of the Patio de los Naranjos. The cathedral interior. The Alcázar gardens. The river at sunset. Tapas culture. The Giralda. The Triana neighbourhood.

It's well made. The production values are high - the photography is excellent, the editing is precise, the sound design is rich. For a visitor with one day in Seville who doesn't have time to attend an actual flamenco show or see the Feria, the film provides a reasonable approximation of the emotional textures of the city.

For visitors with more time, the film is supplementary. It's a useful framing experience at the start of a visit - it gives you images to look for as you walk around the actual city - and it's a useful summarising experience at the end. Most Sevillanos would tell you the film cannot replace the city itself, and they would be right.

If you've already watched the film, you can skip the rest of this track. If you haven't and don't plan to, here is the short version of what it's saying. Seville is a city of strong physical sensations - heat, scent, music, ritual, movement of crowds at certain hours of certain days. The structures and architecture you visit during the day are the framework for those sensations. The film tries to make that framework legible in fifteen minutes.

The next track is about Aurora - the evening light show. If you're here in the daytime, you might want to come back for that one in the evening. We'll set that up next.

TRACK 17 / 20

Aurora

★★ HERO

> **STOP & LOOK**
> *If you're reading this in daytime, save this track for your evening return visit. If you're already up on the walkway after sunset, find a spot where you can see the underside of the canopy clearly. The Aurora light projections will be playing across the wood above you.*

Aurora is the light show. It plays every night from sunset to closing time. It is the reason your ticket includes a second visit within forty-eight hours.

What it is. The underside of the entire canopy - all six parasols, the connecting walkways, the central viewing platform - is fitted with LED lighting. After sunset, the lighting projects colour and pattern across the woodwork. The colours flow, shift, pulse, and respond to inputs in ways that change every night.

What makes it unusual. The light show is driven by an AI algorithm rather than a fixed recorded sequence. The algorithm reads real-time data from sensors mounted on the structure - ambient temperature, humidity, movement of people on the walkways, sometimes other inputs. It then generates the light patterns in real time based on what it's reading. The promotional language from the operators says no two nights are ever the same. That's literally true in the sense that the algorithm never produces the same sequence twice. Whether you would notice the difference between one night's show and the next is a different question - the visual vocabulary stays consistent, but the specific timing and colour shifts vary.

When it runs. Sunset varies seasonally. In summer - June through August - Aurora typically starts around nine in the evening. In winter - November through February - it starts around six thirty or seven. The show then runs continuously until the walkway closes at eleven thirty. You don't need a separate ticket. Your daytime ticket includes the evening return.

How to see it. There are two ways. From below, standing on the elevated plaza or in the street, looking up at the underside of the canopy. The view from underneath is the most dramatic - the wood becomes a giant projection screen, and the colours fill your entire field of view. From above, walking the rooftop walkway after dark, you see the city lights of Seville below, and the canopy itself underneath your feet glowing in colours. Both are worth seeing.

What it's for. The light show was added to the project as a way of activating the structure in the evening. It also made the Setas one of the few cultural attractions in Seville that can be experienced after dark - most museums close at five or six. Aurora gives Seville an evening icon. It's an addition to the original architectural project, not part of Mayer's original design, and Sevillanos have mixed opinions about it. Some love it as a beautiful piece of public art. Some find it gimmicky. Visitors almost universally find it worth seeing once.

If you have not yet seen it tonight, come back. The walkway and the canopy under coloured light is one of the most unusual urban experiences in Spain.

TRACK 18 / 20

What Seville Decided About Itself

CONTEXT

> **STOP & LOOK**
> *Find any quiet spot - on the walkway, on the elevated plaza, or back at street level. This is a reflective track. The Setas have been open for fifteen years. The city has had time to work out what they think.*

The Setas have been open since twenty eleven. Fifteen years. That's long enough for an honest verdict.

The short version is that Seville has accepted them.

The acceptance was not immediate. For the first three or four years after opening, the structure was a flashpoint. Local newspapers ran regular opinion pieces criticising the cost, the design, and the disruption to the surrounding neighbourhood. The municipal elections of twenty fifteen included debates about whether the structure should be modified or even partly demolished. Polls during this period consistently showed that a majority of Sevillanos under forty liked it, and a majority of Sevillanos over sixty did not.

Three things changed the dynamic.

The first was time. As the wooden surface weathered and the surrounding neighbourhood reorganised around the new structure, the Setas began to look less like an alien insertion and more like a feature of the city. The skin of the wood silvered. The plantings around the perimeter grew in. New cafés and bars opened on the adjacent streets, drawn by the foot traffic. The market underneath stabilised as a working part of Sevillian food shopping. The Antiquarium became one of the city's serious archaeological assets. By twenty seventeen or so, the Setas had been absorbed into the daily reality of the centre of Seville.

The second was the children. People who grew up in Seville after twenty eleven have no memory of the empty plaza or the old market. For them, the Setas have always been there. Local schoolchildren who came up the walkway on field trips at age eight are now young adults. The structure is part of the city of their childhood. They will not vote to demolish it.

The third was economic. Studies by the University of Seville have shown the structure generated approximately one hundred and fifty-four million euros in surrounding economic activity by twenty twenty-two. The public investment - one hundred and two million euros - has effectively been earned back through tourism revenue, retail growth, and property value increases in the adjacent streets. The cost overrun that was politically toxic in two thousand eight is, fifteen years later, paid for.

The Setas are now what Seville has decided to be. A city with a Roman foundation, a medieval Islamic layer, a Gothic Christian apex, a baroque flourish, an Enlightenment plan, a nineteenth-century reform, an early twentieth-century stagnation, a Civil War, a Franco-era recovery, a democratic transition, and a twenty-first-century architectural statement. The Setas are the latest layer in that stack. They will not be the last.

The next track is what to do when you come down. The neighbourhood around the structure is full.

TRACK 19 / 20

Around the Square

OBJECT

> **STOP & LOOK**
> *Once you come down from the walkway, exit the structure into Plaza de la Encarnación. Look at the streets radiating outward. The neighbourhood is dense, walkable, and full of places worth a stop. This track is your map.*

The neighbourhood around the Setas is one of the better areas of central Seville to wander.

Three minutes south, along Calle Cuna or Calle Álvarez Quintero, you reach the Plaza del Salvador. This is one of the great drinking plazas of Seville. The Iglesia del Salvador, an enormous baroque church, dominates one side. The plaza in front of the church fills with Sevillanos every evening from about seven o'clock onwards, standing with glasses of beer and small plates of food from the surrounding bars. The custom is called botellón when done by young people, but the older version - just standing in the square having a drink - is part of the rhythm of the city.

Five minutes further south you reach Plaza Nueva and, just beyond it, the cathedral and the Alcázar. We covered both in earlier tours.

Three minutes north of the Setas is the Plaza Cristo de Burgos with the giant ficus trees that inspired Jürgen Mayer's design. Worth a visit, especially in early evening when the trees are lit and the cafés around the square are open. Walk under the trees and look up at the canopy. You'll see the source of the Setas.

Ten minutes north is the Alameda de Hércules. The Alameda is a long tree-lined square, one of the oldest public squares in Europe - laid out in fifteen seventy-four by the Count of Barajas - with twin Roman columns at one end topped by statues of Hercules and Julius Caesar. The columns themselves are second-century AD Roman, originally from a temple in the Roman city. They have been standing in this square since the late sixteenth century. The Alameda is the centre of Sevillian nightlife.

Fifteen minutes north, at the far edge of the old city, is the Basílica de la Macarena. Home of the Virgin of the Macarena, the most venerated Madonna statue of Seville's Holy Week. Even on a non-Holy-Week visit the basilica is worth seeing.

For tapas, the streets immediately around the Setas are full of bars. Three I'd recommend without reservation. Bar Eslava, ten minutes west, has won multiple national tapas awards and is famous for its honeyed Iberian pork and its slow-cooked egg. La Brunilda, ten minutes south, is small and reservation-only but does excellent modern Andalusian small plates. Casa Morales, near the cathedral, is a working-class tavern that has been operating since eighteen fifty and

serves the most traditional Sevillian tapas in the city.

The Mercado de la Encarnación underneath the Setas, as we noted, is itself a good lunch option.

The last track is what to see next in Seville, if you have time.

TRACK 20 / 20

What's Next

CLOSE

> **STOP & LOOK**
> *Exit the Setas and stand in Plaza de la Encarnación. Look south, in the direction of the Giralda. This is the closing track.*

You've just spent about an hour with one of the most ambitious pieces of contemporary architecture in southern Europe.

A quick wrap-up on practical information. Tickets in twenty twenty-six are sixteen euros general admission, twelve for children five to sixteen, free under five. Your ticket includes two visits within forty-eight hours - use them by going up once in late afternoon and once after dark for Aurora. The walkway is open every day from nine thirty in the morning to eleven thirty at night, with last entry at eleven. Closed only on Christmas Day and New Year's Day. The Antiquarium below is a separate ticket of two and a half euros, free with a Real Alcázar ticket, and is closed on Mondays.

Five recommendations for what to see next in Seville.

First and most important - the Cathedral and the Giralda. Eight minutes south of where you're standing. The largest Gothic cathedral in the world. Christopher Columbus's tomb. The Giralda bell tower, originally the minaret of the Almohad great mosque you met in the Antiquarium downstairs. If you have one day in Seville beyond the Setas, this is the day.

Second - the Real Alcázar. Twelve minutes south, just past the cathedral. The oldest royal palace still in use anywhere in Europe. King Felipe the Sixth uses the upper apartments when his family visits. Almohad foundations, Pedro the First's fourteenth-century Mudéjar masterpiece, Habsburg additions, Bourbon gardens. Game of Thrones used parts of it for the Water Gardens of Dorne in twenty fourteen. Plan two and a half to three hours.

Third - Plaza de España. Fifteen minutes south, past the cathedral, in Maria Luisa Park. Built for the nineteen twenty-nine Ibero-American Exposition - the same year as the Poble Espanyol on Montjuïc in Barcelona, by complete coincidence. It's one of the most photographed semicircular plazas in the world. Best at sunset.

Fourth - the Museo de Bellas Artes. Second-most-important fine arts museum in Spain after the Prado. Murillo, Zurbarán, Valdés Leal, and the great Sevillian baroque painters in the building they were painting for. Quieter than the cathedral, never crowded, two hours.

Fifth - Triana. Cross the Puente de Triana bridge from the cathedral side. The traditional working-class neighbourhood of old Seville, home of flamenco, ceramics, bullfighters, and sailors. Have dinner at one of the riverside restaurants and watch the sun set behind the Giralda

from the other side of the water.

Thank you for walking through the Setas with me. Most people only visit Seville once in their lifetime. The Mushrooms are now part of what Seville is. So is the Roman city under your feet. So is the cathedral down the road. So is the Alcázar. All of it is one continuous city, two thousand four hundred years old, still in business.

Seville is yours now. Travel safely.